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ARAVIND ADIGA'S *THE WHITE TIGER* (2008)

'Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger*: 'A Dark Story' or a Glorious Tale'?

At the start of Balram's first letter to Wen Jiabao, Balram promises to describe his 'dark story' (p.9) to the Chinese leader. Balram prays that the gods will shine light on this story. This early description of Balram's life as 'dark' appears to be ominous and pessimistic. However, by the end of the novel, the 'dark' perspective has been replaced by the claim that Balram's life has been a 'glorious tale' (p.292) and 'an amazing success story' (p.299).

Good morning, ladies and gentlemen. Most centres have chosen *The White Tiger* as their prescribed novel for 2025 to 2027. Judging from the high quality of the essays that we saw at the December 2025 marking session, it was obvious that our candidates had engaged meaningfully with the text. Perhaps because they had found the story to be relatable in so many contexts to their own life experiences in South Africa, they responded to the two *White Tiger* essay topics with relish. Their answers were frequently thoughtful and autonomous. Therefore, the IEB and especially Peter Ruddock, have made an inspired choice with Aravind Adiga's first novel, the winner of the Man Booker Prize in 2008.

However, in my own classroom and, I am sure, in many other classrooms, I often found my candidates trying to impose a severely reductionist reading on this complex and nuanced novel. The pivotal question which fascinated my students centred on the extent to which Balram must be held accountable for the murder of Mr Ashok and the probable sacrifice of his extended family in Laxmangarh. To be fair, the text does not confirm that the newspaper article entitled 'Family of 17 Murdered in North Indian village' (p.314) refers to Balram's family, but this is very likely. Did Balram have no other choice? Do we condone his despicable behaviour and instead celebrate his escaping the Rooster Coop and setting up White Tiger Taxis in Bangalore? In Macchiavellian terms, does the end justify the means? Is Balram's story 'dark' or 'glorious'? Adiga has certainly tasked us with a deeply ethical question that cannot be answered in a simplistically binary manner.

Fascinating and essential as this issue is, it is dangerous because it risks turning *The White Tiger* into nothing more than a perverted moral fable. The novel is rich

and dense, and so its depth and substance are impoverished by such a thin reading.

Therefore, this paper argues that we must encourage our candidates to read the novel in a more intelligent way. To dig deeper, to excavate, so that, while they still think carefully about the moral dilemma confronting Balram, they also move beyond this, to achieve a broader and much more informed understanding of the context which persuades Balram to escape.

This morning, my paper will ask three simple but essential questions of *The White Tiger*: Why? How? What?

With regard to the 'Why?', I have always felt that the pivotal issue with any literary text is the author's agenda. What is the author's project? The agenda may be multiple; it may not be clear; candidates may disagree about what the author is trying to say and to achieve; but, if we have not understood, or created our own at least tentative understanding of, why the author wrote the novel, we have no foundation, no context, for our engagement with the text. We cannot start with nothing.

Unfortunately, or more probably fortunately, Aravind Adiga is not helpful here. Trawling through the many interviews that Adiga has given down the years, we find that he has many answers to this question. Try as we may, we cannot pin him down. He is evasive, contradictory.

Thus, in one interview, Adiga claims categorically that 'at its heart, *The White Tiger* is about a man's quest for freedom. Although the novel is set in a socio-political context, the novel is really about a man trying to understand his life without any help from his background and his family. A man being put into an entirely new world and having to understand for himself about the trap and how he is going to break out of that trap.' Adiga concludes that he has 'no political agenda' in his book. This claim suggests that Adiga's principal interest lies in Balram the individual, and that the portrayal of modern India, while present, is less important.

But Adiga is not always so unambiguous. Elsewhere he has stressed the importance of the economic factors in the novel. He explains that his purpose is to highlight the tension between those who have and those who have not. India is a country of extraordinary contrasts, the confluence of culture and technology, the past and the present. All this is seen through Balram's eyes. From this

perspective, Balram is essentially depicted as the individual who experiences, witnesses, and documents, these many contrasts. He is Adiga's agent of change, yes, but this reading divests Balram of his marvelous blend of quirkiness, obduracy, ambition, and affinity with beauty, such as poetry. This reading ignores Balram's conservative views, for example, about cell phones. He explains to Wen Jiabao that 'mobile phones cause cancer in the brain and shrink your masculinity; the Japanese invented them to diminish the white man's brain and balls at the same time. I heard this at the bus stand one night' (p.305).

So, where is the Balram of the chandeliers, the Balram who fears lizards, the Balram of the Black Fort? No, we cannot trivialise Adiga's splendid portrayal of Balram in this way.

Furthermore, our confusion about Adiga's agenda is exacerbated when we read his belief that 'a novel as a piece of work has to be ambiguous, and the reader's response must be ambivalent, uncertain exactly of what the book is saying, because if the book is clear in what it is saying, it ceases to be a good work of art. Instead, it becomes a political statement. India is a country of corruption, but it also has a sense of idealism. As an artist, my job is to dramatise what is happening without indicating that there is an obvious answer to what is going on round me.'

Adiga's suggestion that 'ideally, there should be no message or point to the novel' is anarchic and surely very unhelpful for our candidates.

So, how are we to navigate our way through this remarkable novel?

I have always preferred to think about novels as shaped by their specific historical and socio-economic circumstances. A dialogic relationship occurs between a piece of fiction and the environment in which it is created. Fiction provides a useful space in which writers can explore the pressing issues of their day, issues that bother, or perplex, or excite them.

And so, in our attempt to understand Adiga's agenda, I am reminded of the crucial opening lines in the novel *Agnes Grey* written in 1847 by the Victorian feminist author, Anne Brontë (1820-1849). Brontë stresses that 'All true histories contain instruction'. *The White Tiger* does indeed instruct, warn, and raise awareness about the poverty, the corruption, and the appalling education and health issues confronting Indians in the Darkness.

Therefore, my reading of *The White Tiger* and Adiga's purpose, is that we should not approach it through just one lens. As I have shown, Adiga is working with a large canvas that intentionally supports, and is enriched by, a plurality of different authorial preoccupations. Balram is of course central to the novel and integral to the text, both as a strongly delineated individual, and as the voice through which Adiga conveys his opinions and perceptions of India. *The White Tiger* integrates its consideration of Balram the man with the novel's appraisal of contemporary India, the India of 2008.

So far, my paper has suggested that Adiga writes *The White Tiger* with a double agenda: to create a story that integrates its examination of the pivotal character Balram with its detailed consideration of Balram's world. Balram's personal and private story complements the novel's exploration of the more public face of India.

I would now like to look at the second part of my presentation: the 'How'. Precisely 'How' does Adiga narrate his story? What narrative techniques does he use to best convey the richness and the abundance of his novel? How does he construct the text? This aspect of *The White Tiger*, its narratology, has been relatively neglected in the Adiga scholarship. This is regrettable. For a writer may have a compelling agenda and a robust storyline, but the 'Why' and the 'What' are wasted if the audience remains indifferent and unengaged. The 'How' is arguably the key factor in the ultimate success of any literary text. We must familiarise our students with a good understanding of the potential and capacity, but also the dangers, of various types of narration, such as the first-person voice, the third-person voice, the omniscient narrator, and what is usually described as the third-person omniscient narrator.

Aravind Adiga is adept with his use of the 'How', telling his story in a clever way, so that the attention of the audience never flags. He exploits the rich potential not only of the first-person narrator but also of the epistolary novel.

In *The White Tiger*, Adiga uses one first-person narrator, Balram Halwai. The story is entirely Balram's: his voice speaks clearly to the audience; his signature is clearly evident. As with all first-person narrators, Balram has complete control over us. We rely entirely on his descriptions, his opinions, and his emphases, because we have no other source of authority. We are vulnerable and we are at his mercy. He positions us to share his opinion of Mr Ashok, Pinky Madam, and Kusum. The detailed descriptions of Laxmangarh and the landlords, of New Delhi with its skyscrapers and slums, and of 'the great secondhand book market of

Darya Ganj' (p. 252), seem credible and reliable. Even though we may disapprove of Balram's questionable values and ethics, and his cruel treatment of Ram Persad, we nevertheless feel an intimacy, a closeness, to Balram. We want to trust him because this makes us feel safe. We want to believe that he is open and transparent.

But this is naïve and dangerous. Balram is in fact highly opinionated, solipsistic, and unreliable. He is often evasive, or delays revealing the truth. A good example of this occurs at the end of the first letter, 'The First Night'. Balram explains that he successfully enters the Black Fort and looks down on Laxmangarh which 'looked like the most beautiful sight on earth' (p.42). He continues, 'I leaned out from the edge of the fort in the direction of my village – and then I did something too disgusting to describe to you. Well, actually, I *spat*. Again and again. And then, whistling and humming, I went back down the hill.' (p. 42) He does not explain why he spits at his home, 'the most beautiful sight on earth', or why he is 'whistling and humming' as he goes down the hill. It is only 40 pages later, towards the end of the second letter, 'The Second Night', that Balram describes again, and in substantially more detail, his behaviour at the Black Fort. Only now does he reveal that he has made the crucial decision to abandon his family and the Darkness in his attempt to escape the Rooster Coop. Therefore, this watershed moment is initially seriously downplayed by Balram.

At the end of 'The Sixth Night', after he has murdered Mr Ashok, Balram goes back to collect Dharam. This is extraordinarily dangerous. At the station, when Balram is about to board the train and escape, he sees 'a filthy creature, a baby boy' 'having the time of his life, playing with the water and splashing it on passers-by' (p.287). Suddenly, without explaining to us why he changes his mind. He 'sighs, and gets up, and curses himself, and walks out of the station' (p.287) to save Dharam. Balram never explains why the baby has such a powerful impact on him, leaving us to assume that the baby's innocence and purity have softened this hardened criminal.

Adiga's use of the epistolary novel form of first-person writing is extremely interesting. An epistolary novel is a novel of letters, a novel that consists entirely of letters written either by one or more characters, letters which may or may not be answered. *The White Tiger* contains eight letters, written by Balram over the period of one week, to Wen Jiabao, the Premier of China, who is soon to arrive in India on an official state tour. Wen Jiabao wants to discover the secrets of entrepreneurship, as practised in the electronics hub of Bangalore, where Balram

runs White Tiger Taxis. Balram hopes to meet Wen Jiabao and writes to him ostensibly to tell him, 'the truth about Bangalore' (p. 6) and his 'life's story' (p.6).

Does Balram actually send his letters to Wen Jiabao, or do the letters remain unsent? The jury is still out on this matter. Wen Jiabao does not answer, but Balram is so invested in his project that we would be disappointed if the letters do not arrive. On the other hand, had Wen Jiabao replied, this would have ruined Adiga's insistence on what we might describe as 'the Balram gaze'. The focus is entirely on Balram.

Because the letters are written over seven days, we wonder if this is a potential allusion to the Creation. If so, which Creation? Balram's creation as an entrepreneur, as the novel's example of the individual who has escaped the Rooster Coop, or the creation of a new and better India? Or something much more mystical, spiritual? It seems strange to attach a Biblical allusion to someone as hard and uncompromising as Balram.

An epistolary novel is a confessional type of writing. Balram admits to Wen Jiabao that he murdered Ashok and that the Stork probably killed his entire family as revenge. Balram is friendly, cheerful, and often very funny, but he also offers serious commentary on politics and the state of the world. He envisions a new India that aligns closely with emerging countries such as China. This is very likely why he chooses to write to Wen Jiabao. Balam believes that 'the white people are on the way out...White men will be finished with my lifetime. There are blacks and reds too, but I have no idea what they're up to...My humble prediction: in twenty years' time, it will just be us yellow men and brown men at the top of the pyramid, and we'll rule the whole world' (p.305).

Adiga has therefore made an astute choice of narrative form. By writing an epistolary novel, he achieves a greater intimacy between audience and character than can be achieved in a conventional first-person novel. Reading an epistolary novel is a truly immersive experience.

The epistolary novel has always been a niche literary genre. It is often chosen when the writer wishes to empower and give a voice to a disadvantaged or marginalised individual, someone whose voice has traditionally been silenced and ignored.

It was the Augustan novelist, Samuel Richardson (1689-1761), who first used the epistolary novel in a significant and conspicuous manner. All three of

Richardson's novels, *Pamela; or Virtue Rewarded* (1740), *Clarissa; or the History of a Young Lady* (1748), and *The History of Sir Charles Grandison* (1753) are major epistolary novels. In *Pamela*, a young servant girl writes to her parents, describing her sustained struggles against the advances of her master, Mr B. In this way, Richardson stresses the challenges of social hierarchies in eighteenth-century England. This work established the potential of the epistolary form for providing psychological depth and moral instruction.

Many other writers since Richardson have used the epistolary novel to articulate the experiences of individuals oppressed in terms of gender, race, and sexual orientation. I think here of texts such as Anne Brontë's *The Tenant of Wildfell Hall* (1848), Alice Walker's *The Color Purple* (1982), and Stephen Chbosky's *The Perks of Being a Wallflower* (1999).

But, by choosing the epistolary novel genre to convey Balram's life in the Rooster Coop, Aravind Adiga has only to a limited extent remained faithful to his literary forebears. Adiga has distorted the conventional trope of the virtuous victim because, while Balram is undoubtedly a victim initially, he is not virtuous. He is a villain, admittedly in some readers' eyes a heroic villain. However, regardless of how we choose to read Balram, we can agree that Adiga has done something much more virile and muscular with his victim. Balram is never insipid, tepid, or boring. He revels in his unethical behaviour.

And this takes me to the third and final part of my paper, the 'What'. I have already suggested that the 'What' integrates Balram's own specific story with a thoughtful consideration of some of the socio-political issues confronting contemporary India. By using Balram's voice to describe these issues, Adiga efficiently connects these diverse threads of the narrative, so that the novel moves easily between Balram's experiences and the social commentary. The commentary is embedded in Balram's experiences.

Adiga has referred to Balram's quest for freedom. Balram is trapped in the Darkness, his term for the poverty-stricken rural areas of India that lack the most basic of resources. Balram's village, Laxmangarh, is generic; similar villages are found across India. Every aspect of life in Laxmangarh is controlled by the Landlords: the Buffalo, the Wild Boar, the Stork, and the Raven. The villagers are supine and apparently indifferent to their fate, knowing that if they challenge the Landlords, their families will suffer grievously. Balram also uses the metaphor of the Rooster Coop, the symbol of the roosters who passively await their fate in the marketplace in Old Delhi. Balram explains that 'the roosters in the coop smell the

blood from above. They see the organs of their brothers lying around them. They know they're next. Yet they do not rebel. They do not try to get out of the coop' (p.173). Balram concludes, 'The very same thing is done with human beings in this country' (p.174).

However, Balram is different. He writes to Kusum, his grandmother, 'I can't live the rest of my life in a cage, Granny. I'm so sorry' (p.278). But he is not sorry. He is the White Tiger, superior to his fellow humans. And thus, the novel documents his carefully planned murder of Mr Ashok and the theft of the red bag with its seven hundred thousand rupees. This money funds Balram's career as a successful entrepreneur in Bangalore.

Balram and Vijay, the bus conductor with his shiny uniform and whistle, are the only characters who escape the Darkness. Balram admires Vijay very much, explaining 'Vijay's family were pigherds, which meant they were the lowest of the low, yet he had made it up in life. Somehow, he had befriended a politician. People said he had let the politician dip his beak in his backside. Whatever he had to do, he had done: he was the first entrepreneur I knew of' (p.31). In common with Vijay, Balram also does what he has to do in his quest for freedom. He murders a man of whom he is undoubtedly fond; he steals a very large sum of money; and he knows that the Stork, Ashok's father, will seek revenge on his family in the direst of ways.

This is the moral debate, the ambiguity, which fascinates our matrics and which, intriguing as it is, can obscure Adiga's broader agenda. Balram escapes, but at what cost? He writes that 'three months after I came to Bangalore, I went to a temple and performed last rites there for all of them: Kusum, Kishan, and all my aunts, cousins, nephews, and nieces. I even said a prayer for the water buffalo' (p.314). Does the inclusion of the water buffalo suggest that Balram is in truth mocking his family? Does he feel guilty when he reads the newspaper article 'Family of 17 Murdered in North Indian village'? The answer to these significant questions comes at the very end of the novel when Balram writes, 'I'll never say I made a mistake that night in Delhi when I slit my master's throat' (p.320), 'it was all worthwhile to know, just for a day, just for an hour, just for a *minute*, what it means not to be a servant' (p.321).

Balram has no regrets. His comment that 'whatever Vijay had to do, he had done' is entirely accurate for his own story. He has to kill Ashok and sacrifice his family if he wants to escape the Darkness. And so our disapproval of his amoral behaviour is tempered by a powerful awareness that he has been extraordinarily

brave and resolute. He has taken control of his destiny and achieved his goals. The old Muslim bookseller in Darya Ganj explains the lines of Urdu poetry, 'You were looking for the key for years /But the door was always open' (p.253). This poetry is the catalyst for Balram's determination to access that door. On the other hand, the fact that he has no family values towards his extended family, even towards his brother Kishan, is disgraceful. But Balram does go back for Dharam and takes him to Bangalore where Dharam attends a good English school and can 'pronounce English like a rich man's son. He can say 'pizza' the way Mr Ashok said it' (p.316). However, because Dharam 'has got it all figured out' (p.316), Balram explains that he will probably have 'to kill' (p.316) Dharam in the future. Is this comment facetious or serious? Probably the latter.

So, should we prioritise his wicked behaviour, or what he terms as his 'amazing success story'? Do we have to prioritise? Or can we sit on the fence?

This takes us back to the ambivalent title of my paper: is the novel 'a dark story' or a 'glorious tale'? What would Vikram, Balram's father, have thought of his son's behaviour? In a much-quoted remark, Vikram says, 'My whole life, I have been treated like a donkey. All I want is that one son of mine – at least one – live like a man' (p.30). Is Vikram's definition of how 'to live like a man' based on ethical conduct, or material success?

Balram's family constitute an interesting context of the novel. Balram's parents are intelligent individuals who are deeply aware of the difficulties confronting their sons in the Darkness. Balram describes Vikram as a 'thinking' (p.24) man. While the other rickshaw drivers 'crouch near the back [of the teashop] in that hunched-over, squatting posture common to servants in every part of India' (p.24), Vikram 'never crouched…He preferred to stand, no matter how long he had to wait and how uncomfortable it got for him' (p.24). Vikram has a dignity and gravitas about him. And Balram's mother challenges the Darkness even in death. As she is incinerated, Balram notices that 'her toes [begin] to curl up, offering resistance to what was being done to them. Kusum shoved the foot into the fire, but it would not burn…My mother wasn't going to let them destroy her…This mud was holding her back; this big, swelling mound of big ooze. She was trying to fight the black mud; her toes were flexed and resisting; but the mud was sucking her in, sucking her in' (p. 17). Balram realises that 'the same would happen to me when I died and they brought me here. Nothing would get liberated here' (p.18).

Had Balram's parents lived, they would have resisted Kusum's treatment of both Kishan and Balram, taking them out of school and putting them to work in the teashop.

However, I would like to defend Kusum against the hostility and vitriol levelled against her by many readers. I accept that Kusum is a thoroughly unpleasant individual who shows no affection to her extended family. She is not demonstrative. She has no time for the values of education and Balram's aspirations to rise in life. She is often accused of being selfish, but when we ask for proof, it is hard to come by. It is ignorant to criticise her intentions. She is the matriarch of a large, improvident family. The women do not bring in money; they work at home, important domestic work yes, but interrupted by petty squabbles and the removal of ticks from one another's bodies. The men, poorly educated, work in menial jobs, such as in the teashop. Kusum's job is to feed her family, to provide for them. The grinding poverty and disadvantage experienced by the family mean that there is no time for what might be considered luxuries. Survival is what matters.

Kishan's arranged marriage to the daughter of an apparently wealthy family means that the family 'screwed the girl's family hard' (p.50) in terms of the dowry they paid to Kusum. Balram recalls that 'thinking about it even now makes my mouth fill with water: five thousand rupees cash, all crisp new unsoiled notes fresh from the bank, plus a Hero bicycle, plus a thick gold necklace for Kishan' (p. 61). 'After the wedding, Kusum Granny took the five thousand rupees and the Hero cycle and the thick gold necklace' (p. 61). There was no possibility that Kusum would wobble around the village on the Hero bicycle or that she would use the five thousand rupees or the gold necklace for herself. Those resources would be used to feed the family. Therefore, I suggest that the prevailing antagonism towards Kusum is ignorant and unjust, and is the consequence of our well-fed, middle-class learners who do not understand the appalling poverty experienced by the inhabitants of the Darkness. Kusum is a horrible person, but she must be seen through a more informed, more realistic lens.

Adiga also offers an unflinching indictment of the serious social and economic problems confronting India. In his interviews, Adiga's love and patriotism for India are obvious; he cares deeply for his country. He criticises not to condemn, but to raise awareness about what must be fixed. He is proud, for instance, of India's growth as a key player in the industrial Global South, and of India's independence in 1947. However, he deplores the sustained Hindu-Muslim hostility that has plagued India ever since Partition in 1947 when Pakistan was

created in the attempt to give the Muslim people their own homeland. Balram's abuse of Ram Persad's Muslim faith, to achieve Balram's goal of becoming the first driver and driving Ashok and Pinky Madam to Delhi, is 'dark', not 'glorious'.

The school and hospital in Laxmangarh are in a disgraceful condition. The schoolteacher does not teach because he has not received his government salary for six months. Not only does he undertake 'a Gandhian protest to retrieve his missing wages' (p.33), but he also steals the lunch money and the uniforms sent by the government for the children. Balram explains that 'no one blamed the schoolteacher for doing this. You can't expect a man in a dung heap to smell sweet...Some [parents] were even proud of him, for having got away with it so cleanly' (p.33). But Adiga reserves his strongest criticism for the hospital where Balram and Kishan take their father who is dying of tuberculosis. There are no doctors, nurses, no functional beds, and no pharmacy. Goat faeces cover the floors. The queue of the sick keeps growing; 'the line of diseased eyes, raw wounds, and delirious mouths' (p.49) lengthens steadily. Eventually Balram's father dies among the goat turds. Balram also learns that corruption is rife in the country's medical services, whereby the allocation of doctors to the country hospitals depends entirely on which doctors can bribe the authorities with the most money.

Adiga shows that corruption is endemic throughout India. In Delhi, Ashok and his father spend copious amounts of money in their attempts to bribe government ministers to offer them tax exemptions for their coal business. Balram himself bribes the police in Bangalore to force the rival taxi company to close down.

Ladies and gentlemen, this morning my paper has tried to explore some of the more interesting and contentious issues that inform *The White Tiger*. Adiga makes us think; this is not an easy novel that offers glib and facile answers. While I was writing this paper, I frequently found that whenever I made a point, I had to contradict or revisit my initial premise. Just as there are a thousand Indias, there are a thousand ways to read this splendid text.

Thank you.

All quotations are taken from *The White Tiger* (Aravind Adiga), 2008, Simon & Schuster, Bombay.